

AGEI Agent Classification and Governance Model

Abstract

As organizations increasingly deploy AI systems capable of reasoning, planning, retrieving information, interacting with tools, and executing actions, the term "agent" has become a broad label applied to fundamentally different categories of systems.

This creates a governance challenge.

Not all agents possess the same authority, autonomy, memory, context access, or operational impact. As a result, applying a single governance model to all agentic systems is insufficient.

The Agent Governance and Evidence Infrastructure (AGEI) introduces a classification framework that categorizes agents based on functional role and governance characteristics. The framework enables organizations to align governance controls, oversight mechanisms, authority delegation, and evidence requirements with the actual risk profile of the agent.

This approach shifts the discussion away from model capability and toward organizational accountability.

1. Introduction

Many discussions surrounding agentic AI begin with a simple question:

"What can the agent do?"

While useful, this question is incomplete.

Organizations do not govern human employees based solely on capability.

Instead, governance considers:

- Authority
- Responsibility
- Information access
- Decision rights
- Accountability
- Organizational impact

The same principle applies to AI systems.

An agent that drafts an email should not be governed in the same manner as an agent authorized to approve financial transactions, access medical records, or coordinate multiple autonomous systems.

Effective governance therefore requires a structured method for classifying agents according to their operational role and governance risk.

2. Agent Classification Principles

AGEI classifies agents using two dimensions:

Functional Classification

Defines the operational purpose of the agent.

Governance Characteristics

Defines the level of authority, context, memory, autonomy, and impact associated with the agent.

Together these dimensions determine the governance requirements applicable to the system.

3. Functional Agent Categories

3.1 Assistant Agent

Purpose

Assist humans in producing content, analysis, summaries, recommendations, or research.

Characteristics

- No independent execution authority
- Human remains responsible for final action
- Limited operational impact

Examples

- Writing assistants

- Research assistants
- Knowledge retrieval assistants
- Meeting summarization systems

Governance Focus

- Transparency
 - Source attribution
 - Output review
 - Evidence of generated content
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3.2 Workflow Agent

Purpose

Execute predefined business workflows.

Characteristics

- Fixed process
- Approved logic
- Controlled execution path

Examples

- Inventory management
- Claims routing
- Medical record classification
- Automated reporting

Governance Focus

- Change management
- Process approval
- Testing and validation
- Evidence capture

3.3 Routing Agent

Purpose

Determine where information, requests, cases, or actions should be directed.

Characteristics

- Evaluates destination
- May influence operational outcomes
- Limited execution authority

Examples

- Incident routing
- Customer support routing
- Healthcare referral routing
- Escalation routing

Governance Focus

- Routing criteria
- Escalation controls
- Decision evidence
- Performance monitoring

3.4 Monitoring Agent

Purpose

Observe systems, processes, users, or events.

Characteristics

- Continuous observation
- Event detection
- Anomaly identification

Examples

- Compliance monitoring
- Fraud detection
- Security monitoring
- Model drift monitoring

Governance Focus

- Detection thresholds
 - Alerting policies
 - False positive review
 - Event lineage
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3.5 Decision Support Agent

Purpose

Provide recommendations while preserving human decision authority.

Characteristics

- Advisory role
- No independent execution
- Human remains accountable

Examples

- Risk assessment
- Medical recommendations
- Financial analysis
- Compliance assessments

Governance Focus

- Explainability
- Human oversight

- Recommendation traceability
 - Decision evidence
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3.6 Tool-Using Agent

Purpose

Select and invoke approved tools to accomplish objectives.

Characteristics

- Dynamic tool selection
- Expanded operational capability
- Increased governance requirements

Examples

- Data retrieval agents
- CRM interaction agents
- Research agents
- Multi-tool assistants

Governance Focus

- Tool registry
 - Permission management
 - Authority constraints
 - Runtime policy enforcement
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3.7 Execution Agent

Purpose

Execute actions within operational systems.

Characteristics

- Direct operational impact

- May create financial, legal, regulatory, or safety consequences

Examples

- Transaction approval systems
- Infrastructure management agents
- Automated remediation systems
- Claims processing systems

Governance Focus

- Delegated authority
 - Approval requirements
 - Segregation of duties
 - Evidence generation
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3.8 Orchestration Agent

Purpose

Coordinate multiple agents, tools, systems, or workflows.

Characteristics

- Cross-system interaction
- Composite outcomes
- Elevated governance complexity

Examples

- Multi-agent workflows
- Enterprise orchestration systems
- AI coordination platforms

Governance Focus

- Authority inheritance
- Agent-to-agent controls

- Lineage preservation
 - Composite evidence
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3.9 Strategic Agent

Purpose

Pursue broad organizational objectives where execution paths are not predefined.

Characteristics

- High discretion
- Dynamic planning
- Emergent execution patterns

Examples

- Operational optimization
- Cost reduction initiatives
- Resource allocation analysis
- Strategic planning assistance

Governance Focus

- Objective constraints
 - Risk appetite enforcement
 - Human review
 - Continuous oversight
-

4. Governance Characteristics

Functional classification alone is insufficient.

Each agent must also be evaluated using governance characteristics.

Authority

Defines what actions an agent may perform.

Questions include:

- What authority has been delegated?
 - Who delegated it?
 - Under what conditions?
 - For how long?
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Context Access

Defines what information the agent may access during execution.

Examples include:

- Internal documents
- Customer information
- Financial records
- Healthcare records

Context access directly influences governance risk.

Memory Scope

Defines what information the agent may retain between interactions.

Stateless

No retained information.

Session Memory

Information retained temporarily.

Persistent Memory

Information retained across long periods.

Organizational Memory

Information shared across systems and users.

As memory scope increases, governance requirements increase.

Autonomy

Defines the level of discretion granted to the agent.

Tier 1

Human-in-the-loop

Tier 2

Human-on-the-loop

Tier 3

Human-out-of-the-loop

Higher autonomy requires stronger governance controls.

Impact

Defines the potential consequence of incorrect execution.

Impact may include:

- Financial loss
 - Regulatory exposure
 - Operational disruption
 - Reputational harm
 - Safety consequences
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5. Governance Tier Determination

AGEI proposes the following governance equation:

Governance Tier =

Agent Function

- Authority

- Context Access
- Memory Scope
- Autonomy
- Impact

The resulting governance tier determines:

- Oversight requirements
- Approval requirements
- Monitoring requirements
- Evidence requirements
- Audit requirements

6. From Capability Governance to Authority Governance

Many current AI discussions focus on capability.

What can the model do?

What tools can it access?

How autonomous is the workflow?

AGEI proposes a different perspective.

The primary governance question is not capability.

The primary governance question is authority.

Organizations routinely restrict human authority despite capability.

The same principle should apply to AI systems.

Capability does not imply authorization.

Authorization does not imply admissibility.

Execution requires governance.

7. Conclusion

Agentic systems are not a single category of technology.

They represent a spectrum of operational roles with varying levels of authority, autonomy, memory, context access, and organizational impact.

A governance model that treats all agents identically is unlikely to provide sufficient oversight.

The AGEI Agent Classification and Governance Model provides a structured framework for classifying agents according to their operational purpose and governance characteristics.

By focusing on authority, context, memory, autonomy, and impact, organizations can align governance controls with actual operational risk and establish a foundation for evidence-based assurance in increasingly autonomous environments.

The future of AI governance will not be determined by what agents are capable of doing.

It will be determined by what authority they are allowed to exercise, what information they are permitted to access, what they are allowed to remember, and what evidence exists to demonstrate they operated within those boundaries.

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AI-Assisted Development

This document was developed with the assistance of generative artificial intelligence tools used for research support, drafting, editing, organization, and technical review.

All architectural concepts, governance models, technical direction, design decisions, and final editorial approval remain the responsibility of the author.

AI was used as a productivity and drafting aid. Human review, validation, and technical judgment were applied throughout the development of this work.

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